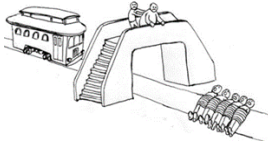


PSY 410 MORAL PSYCHOLOGY

Course Syllabus (CRN: [26650](#))



TR 10:00 – 11:20 AM

B040 Price Science Commons,
University of Oregon

COURSE DESCRIPTION

Moral psychology is the scientific study of how people determine right from wrong, act or fail to act on those standards, judge and punish others for their moral transgressions, and throughout, maintain that they personally are good, even when their actions suggest otherwise. This course explores topics such as moral licensing and hypocrisy, egoism and altruism, empathy and its limits, blame and moral responsibility, the role of intuition versus reason in moral judgment, moral character evaluation, secular and religious deterrence, and moral advancement. There are many ways to approach the study of moral psychology. This course draws most heavily from insights from *social psychology* research, and therefore most topics covered pertain to morality within social contexts, e.g., thinking about, reacting to, influencing, and judging the (im)moral behavior and character of others. However, the course is interdisciplinary in nature, drawing from ideas and research from philosophy, behavioral economics, cognitive psychology, personality psychology, developmental psychology, neuroscience, biology, and other social science fields.

OFFICE HOURS



Instructor

Sarah Dimakis, Ph.D.
sdimakis@uoregon.edu
WR 12:00 – 1:00 PM
Straub 464

Graduate Teaching Fellow

Fiona DeBernardi
fionadeb@uoregon.edu
TBD

CONTACTING US

Please don't hesitate to contact us if you have any questions or concerns! We are always happy to help. When you e-mail us, please add PSY410 in the subject line (e.g., "PSY410 exam question") so that we know which class you are from. If you e-mail us, you can expect to receive a response within 2 business days, and typically earlier. If we do not respond to your email within 2 business days, please resend it because we may have not received it.

COURSE MATERIALS

There is no assigned textbook for this course. All readings will be posted on Canvas at the beginning of the course, including a mixture of empirical articles that conduct original research and review articles that synthesize the research of many scientists. Some review articles ("opinion" articles) offer conjecture from researchers that go beyond the facts of what they or others have observed. Occasionally the readings will be supplemented with short videos or podcast episodes. To maximize your understanding and participation in lectures and discussions, I strongly recommend completing the assigned readings *before the class they correspond to*. Learning to read psychology articles can be challenging, as they are often written for an audience familiar with the specialized terminology of the subfield who have advanced knowledge of the journal article structure. It takes effort and practice to become proficient, but the payoff is well worth it. The readings for this course vary in difficulty—some are written for a general audience, while others are intended for peers in the field. If you find it difficult to complete the readings on time or struggle to remember key details after reading, there is a resource available under the 'Welcome' module on Canvas that offers strategies for identifying and retaining important information from research articles.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

In this course, you will be developing important skills that are valuable outside of university, like introspection, critical thinking, writing, and speaking. You will also be working to improve skills that are necessary to be a consumer and/or producer of research, like reading, communicating about, and critically evaluating psychology research. Upon completion of this course, you will be able to (1) describe and identify important theories and research findings in moral psychology, (2) read novel research in moral psychology from academic journals, and (3) apply moral psychology theory and research findings to experiences in your life.

COURSE MODALITY

This is an in-person course with a lot of opportunities to discuss the material with other students and with the entire class (and trust me, you will want to discuss this material!). Every Tuesday, we will have an interactive lecture. Every Thursday, we will have a 30-minute mini-lecture and then break out into smaller groups to discuss a set of discussion questions before reporting back as a bigger group. Unlike asynchronous online/ASYNC WEB courses, we will meet during scheduled class meeting times in *B040 Price Science Commons*, which is located North of the EMU near Franklin Blvd. I will accommodate absences as described in the Participation section below. If you need additional flexibility, UO encourages you to consider ASYNC WEB courses. If you need accommodation related to a medical or other disability, you can request those by working with the Accessible Education Center.

ESTIMATED STUDENT WORKLOAD

When you complete this course, you will earn 4 credits toward your degree. A four-credit course from the University of Oregon is equivalent to 120 hours of work across the term, or 12 hours per week for 10 weeks. You will spend 30 hours in class, 40 hours on readings (for about 4 hours per week), and the remaining 50 hours completing take home assignments (reading quizzes, research paper, exams).

TECHNICAL REQUIREMENTS

Information and communication outside of class time will occur on our Canvas page. To access our course Canvas site, log into [Canvas](#) using your DuckID. If you have questions about using Canvas, visit the [Canvas support page](#). Canvas and Technology Support also is available by phone (541-346-4357) or by [live chat on the Live Help webpage](#).

GRADING

Your learning will be assessed through take-home free-response exams (40% of your grade), multiple-choice take-home reading and lecture quizzes (30% of your grade), a research paper investigating a moral psychology question (20% of your grade), and participation in in-class discussions (10% of your grade).

Take-Home Exams (x2)	40%
Quizzes (x4, one dropped)	30%
Research Paper	20%
Reading Annotations (two dropped)	10%

The following grid provides the letter grade associated with each percent. If you are within .5% of a grade category, your grade will be rounded up if you have 100% in the Participation grade category. A student may be assigned an "A+" for a final grade if they demonstrate exemplary understanding of the course material across all assessments (> 97% on all four grade categories).

A 93-100%	B 83-86.99%	C 73-76.99%	D 63-66.99%
A- 90-92.99%	B- 80-82.99%	C- 70-72.99%	D- 60-62.99%
B+ 87-89.99%	C+ 77-79.99%	D+ 67-69.99%	F 59.99% or below

TAKE-HOME EXAMS

There are two **take-home exams** for this course. The exams are untimed, and you are encouraged to use notes, readings, and the internet to complete the exam, but the work you submit must be your own (i.e., no collaboration with other students). In 5 essays questions, you will research given case studies and apply what you are learning in class readings, lecture, and discussions to gain a deeper understanding of each case.

QUIZZES

To incentivize you to keep on top of the readings and attend class, there will be four multiple-choice quizzes with 15 questions each. The quizzes are untimed, and you are encouraged to use your notes and readings to complete them, but the work you submit must be your own (i.e., no collaboration with other students). Your final quiz grade will drop the lowest score of the four quizzes.

RESEARCH PAPER

The purpose of the research paper (4-6 paged double spaced) is to apply theories you've learned in the course while diving deeper into a topic of personal interest. You will choose a research topic, search for and read relevant research on the topic, identify a research question, and write a paper describing the research findings and how they answer or fail to answer your research question. You may turn in an optional ungraded **topic proposal** outlining your chosen research question and plan for the structure of your paper at the end of Week 3 for feedback (about 1 page double spaced) and an optional ungraded **first draft** of your paper for feedback Week 7. The **final draft** is due during finals week.

You may choose one of the following topics (which you may interpret in a number of ways) for inspiration, or an alternate, equivalently rigorous topic that you discuss with the instructor prior to turning in your paper:

- (a) Study the moral behavior and/or moral judgments of a subgroup of people or entities (e.g., AI, psychopaths, moral exemplars, infants, small children, nonhuman animals). How and/or why do they differ from the average human adult?
- (b) Investigate how a specific factor (e.g., substance use, interpersonal attraction, emotional state, relationship closeness) influences moral behavior and/or moral judgment. How and/or why does the factor improve or worsen moral behavior and and/or moral judgment?

Your paper should include an introduction, body, and conclusion. In the **introduction** (1-2 paragraphs), pose a research question and explain its importance. At the end of this section, give a one single sentence thesis or "answer" to your research question (e.g., if your question is "does believing in God make us good or bad?", your thesis may be something like "a belief in God primarily makes us good because X, Y, and Z," "a belief in God only makes us good when X, Y, Z conditions are met," or "a belief in God makes us good unless X, Y, and Z occur.") An excellent thesis is typically one that is nuanced, i.e., it describes some limit or constraint rather than just giving a "yes" or "no" answer. Next, the **body** of the paper (2+ pages) provides evidence for your thesis. You should cite at least 5 articles from peer-reviewed scientific journals to support your thesis. Finally, the **conclusion** (1-3 paragraphs) should briefly summarize the important points in the paper, and then describe what there is still left to learn about the topic. In the final paragraph, you may want to describe limitations of the current research, recommend future directions, and/or explain how you would design a study to test a future direction. *In your final paper, please use APA format, including proper in-text citations and a reference page that does not count towards page length. Successful papers will provide a nuanced understanding of the topic, strong empirical evidence to support claims and arguments, and thoughtful discussion of the strengths and limitations of psychological research in answering big, important questions.*

READING ANNOTATIONS

Your participation grade for this course will be based on the percent of class discussions you attend (which happen every Thursday). For each discussion, your group will fill out a form which will record your attendance. **There are ten class discussions in the term, and you may miss 2 without penalty to your grade.** Missing classes due to a religious observance, specific AEC accommodation, military deployment, or a University-sponsored event with signed documentation do not count toward your two absences. Difficult or complex situations that may impact attendance will occur for many of us during the term. This **reason-neutral** policy means that absences are available both for students who *do* want to reach out about their experiences and students who *do not*. If you are feeling ill, please stay home and use one of your two absences. I made the participation policy with this in mind, so please use your absences with care, so they're there for you if you need them.

LATE ASSIGNMENT POLICY

To make it easy to remember, assignments in this course are always due **Sundays at 11:59pm**. In the case that you fall ill or otherwise cannot complete your work on time, I have built flexibility into the course in the following ways:

- All students have one free, no-questions-asked extension to turn in a graded assignment late **for any reason**, no questions asked. If you wish to use your extension, *comment on the assignment "I am using my one free extension"* when you submit it to Canvas. No need to e-mail me that you're using your extension unless you can't find a place to comment!
- Without the pass, if an assignment is turned in more than 24 hours after the due date, the assignment will be marked off 5% (max score is now 95%). If 48 hours have passed, the assignment will be marked off 10% (max score is now 90%). Anything after 72 hours will receive the max late penalty of 15% off (max score is now 85%). All late work must be turned in by the last day of Week 10 of classes (**Friday March 14th by 5pm**) to ensure that all assignments can be graded before the grading deadline.

ACCESS & ACCOMMODATIONS

The University of Oregon and I are dedicated to fostering inclusive, equitable, and accessible learning environments for all students. The [Accessible Education Center](#) (AEC) assists students with disabilities in reducing barriers in the educational experience. You may be eligible for accommodations for a variety of disabilities – apparent disabilities, such as a mobility or physical disability, or non-apparent disabilities, such as chronic illnesses or psychological disabilities. If you have or think you have a disability and experience academic barriers, please contact the Accessible Education Center (Location: 360 Oregon Hall; 541-346-1155; uoaec@uoregon.edu) to discuss appropriate accommodations or support. The details of your disability will be kept confidential with the AEC and you are not expected to share this information with others. However, I invite you to discuss any approved accommodations or access needs at any time with me.

ACCOMMODATIONS FOR RELIGIOUS OBSERVANCES

The University of Oregon respects the right of all students to observe their religious holidays, and will make reasonable accommodations, upon request, for these observances. If you need to be absent from a class period this term because of a religious obligation or observance, please fill out the [Student Religious Accommodation Request form](#) and send it to me within the first weeks of the course so we can make arrangements in advance.

INTERESTED IN GRADUATE SCHOOL IN SOCIAL PSYCHOLOGY?

Please don't hesitate to come to office hours if you'd like to talk to me about graduate school in psychology. I am a recent (Summer 2024) graduate of UO's PhD program in Social Psychology and am always happy to share my experience. I can't speak too much to graduate school in mental health fields (more so to research psychology), but I can direct you to people who can!

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE USE

You are permitted (and encouraged) to use AI tools (e.g., ChatGPT, Grammarly) to assist with brainstorming topic ideas or refining your writing. However, keep in mind that AI can and often does provide inaccurate or overly simplistic responses, and you are responsible for the accuracy and quality of the work that you submit. If you choose to use these tools, then **they must not prevent you from achieving the learning goals of the course**. Relying on AI to think for you – such as copying a response directly from ChatGPT and submitting it as your own -- will hinder your learning and therefore is considered a violation of the academic integrity policy for this course.

ACADEMIC INTEGRITY

Any form of academic dishonesty, including getting outside help on assignments, plagiarizing of any kind, improper use of AI (as outlined in the policy above), or lying to the instructor or the GTF will not be tolerated in this class. You are permitted (and encouraged) to work with other students on brainstorming and reviewing each other's research papers, but the work you submit *must be your own* and therefore should not be a direct copy of another student's work. If you have questions about what is considered academic dishonesty for this course, or if you are struggling with your coursework to the point that you feel you have no choice but to violate our academic integrity policy, please reach out to the instructor to discuss your options for late work. If I detect any academic dishonesty, I will follow the procedure to handle misconduct as outlined by the University, meaning that instances of suspected cheating or plagiarizing will be reported to the University.

CLASSROOM CLIMATE

While studying moral psychology, we are bound to hear from others who do not agree with our moral values, which will cause us to feel deeply uncomfortable. There's nothing we hold more sacred than our moral beliefs. I do not expect to agree with you on everything, and I do not expect you to agree with your classmates on everything. We are a group with diverse backgrounds and experiences. You will never be graded on your moral views and opinions, only the rigor of psychological evidence you provide to support them. In discussion, we must make it a priority that each person in this class has the opportunity to speak and challenge each other's ideas.

For discussions, we will follow the guidelines outlined below (which I am happy to add to). Continued enrollment in the course indicates agreement that you will abide by these guidelines.

- (1) Treat others with respect, even when you disagree with them about their ideas or beliefs. For instance, instead of attacking the speaker (e.g., "you are wrong and dumb for thinking that"), focus on disagreeing with the claim or idea by providing contradictory research findings or personal experiences.
- (2) Listening is just as important as sharing your ideas. Make sure to allow others the chance to contribute to the conversation. If you have been speaking too much (or too little), make sure to adjust accordingly so that we hear from a lot of different perspectives.
- (3) Allow others (and yourself) to make mistakes and learn from them. We don't always say what we mean, and there are things we don't know yet. Open yourself up to learning new things about yourself and give others the space to do the same.

If you do not feel comfortable participating in a class discussion or believe there is more that I could be doing to promote a more effective learning environment, I urge you to come talk to me. I will always listen to your concerns with respect and an open mind and will make adjustments when appropriate.

YOUR WELLBEING

During your college experience, you may feel overwhelmed or stressed, experience anxiety or depression, struggle with relationships, or just need help navigating challenges in your life. If you're facing such challenges, you don't need to handle them on your own--there's help and support on campus. Getting help is a courageous thing to do—for yourself and those you care about. [University Health Services](#) helps students cope with difficult emotions and life stressors. If you need general resources on coping with stress or want to talk with another student who has been in the same place as you, visit the Duck Nest (located in the EMU on the ground floor) and get help from one of the specially trained Peer Wellness Advocates. University Counseling Services (UCS) has a team of dedicated staff members to support you with your concerns, many of whom can provide identity-based support. All clinical services are free and confidential. Find out more at counseling.uoregon.edu or by calling 541-346-3227 (anytime UCS is closed, the After-Hours Support and Crisis Line is available by calling this same number).

BASIC NEEDS

Being able to meet your basic needs is foundational to your success as a student. If you are having difficulty affording food, don't have a stable, safe place to live, or are struggling to meet another need, visit the [UO Basic Needs Resource](#) page for information on how to get support. They have information food, housing, healthcare, childcare, transportation, technology, finances (including emergency funds), and legal support. If your need is urgent, please contact the Care and Advocacy Program by calling 541-346-3216, filling out the [Community Care and Support form](#), or by [scheduling an appointment](#) with an advocate.

ACADEMIC DISRUPTION DUE TO CAMPUS EMERGENCY

In the event of a campus emergency that disrupts academic activities, course requirements, deadlines, and grading percentages are subject to change. Information about changes in this course will be communicated as soon as possible by email, and on Canvas. If we are not able to meet face-to-face, students should immediately log onto Canvas and read any announcements and/or access alternative assignments. Students are also expected to continue coursework as outlined in this syllabus or other instructions on Canvas.

ACADEMIC DISRUPTION DUE TO CAMPUS EMERGENCY

It is generally expected that class will meet unless the University is officially closed for inclement weather. If it becomes necessary to cancel class while the University remains open, this will be announced on Canvas and by email. Updates on inclement weather and closure are also communicated as described on the [Inclement Weather](#) webpage.

REPORTING OBLIGATIONS

I am a designated reporter. For information about my reporting obligations as an employee, please see [Employee Reporting Obligations](#) on the Office of Investigations and Civil Rights Compliance (OICRC) website. Students experiencing sex- or gender-based discrimination, harassment or violence should call the 24-7 hotline 541-346-SAFE [7244] or visit safe.uoregon.edu for help. Students experiencing all forms of prohibited discrimination or harassment may contact the Dean of Students Office at 541-346-3216 or the non-confidential Title IX Coordinator/OICRC at 541-346-3123 to request information and resources. Students are not required to participate in an investigation to receive support, including requesting academic supportive measures. Additional resources are available at investigations.uoregon.edu/how-get-support. I am also a mandatory reporter of child abuse. Please find more information at [Mandatory Reporting of Child Abuse and Neglect](#).

PSY410 MORAL PSYCHOLOGY

Winter 2025 Course Schedule

WEEK	DATE	TOPIC, ASSIGNMENTS, & READINGS
Week 1 - Introduction	Tues 1/7	Lecture topic: Course overview: What is moral psychology? Required readings: Review the syllabus and take note of any questions or concerns you have!
	Thurs 1/9	Mini-lecture & discussion topic: Moral accounting: Do good behaviors license us to misbehave? Required readings: Merritt, A. C., Effron, D. A., & Monin, B. (2010). Moral self-licensing: When being good frees us to be bad. <i>Social and personality psychology compass</i>, 4(5), 344-357.
Week 2 – Understanding moral behavior	Tues 1/14	Lecture topic: Egoistic motives for altruism: Why should we do good things? Required readings: Dunn, E. W., Aknin, L. B., & Norton, M. I. (2014). Prosocial spending and happiness: Using money to benefit others pays off. <i>Current directions in psychological science</i>, 23(1), 41-47.
	Thurs 1/16	Mini-lecture & discussion topic: Empathy and its limits: Should we ditch empathy to make people more moral? Required readings: - Hoffman, M. L. (2008). Empathy and prosocial behavior. <i>Handbook of emotions</i>, 3, 440-455. - Bloom, P. (2017). Other People's Shoes. In <i>Against empathy: The case for rational compassion</i> (pp. 15-56). Random House.
	Sun 1/19	Quiz 1 Due
Week 3 – Understanding immoral behavior (bad barrels)	Tues 1/21	Lecture topic: Bad barrels: Anonymity, unidentified victims, peer influence, and prosocial motives Required readings: - Baumeister, R. F. (2012). Human evil: The myth of pure evil and the true causes of violence. In M. Mikulincer & P. R. Shaver (Eds.), <i>The social psychology of morality: Exploring the causes of good and evil</i> (pp. 367–380). American Psychological Association. - Levine, E. E., & Lupoli, M. J. (2022). Prosocial lies: Causes and consequences. <i>Current Opinion in Psychology</i>, 43, 335-340.
	Thurs 1/23	Mini lecture & discussion topic: Are we all just moral hypocrites? Required readings: DeSteno, D. & Valdesolo, P. (2011). Hypocrisy vs. morality: Why no one should throw stones. <i>Out of character: Surprising truths about the Liar, Cheat, Sinner (and Saint) lurking in all of us</i> (pp. 29-57). New York: Random House, Inc.
	Sun 1/26	Research Paper Outline Due (Optional)

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Week 4 – Understanding immoral behavior (bad apples)	Tues 1/28	Lecture topic: Bad apples: psychopaths, Machiavellians, narcissists, and sadists Required readings: Kiehl, K. A., & Hoffman, M. B. (2011). The criminal psychopath: History, neuroscience, treatment, and economics. <i>Jurimetrics</i>, 51, 355.
	Thurs 1/30	Mini lecture & discussion topic: Are psychopaths morally responsible for their behavior? Required readings: Tullett, A. M. (2022). The Limitations of Social Science as the Arbiter of Blame: An Argument for Abandoning Retribution. <i>Perspectives on Psychological Science</i>. 1-13.
	Sun 2/2	<i>Quiz 2 Due</i>
Week 5 - The moral self	Tues 2/4	Lecture topic: Maintaining a positive moral self-concept when we do bad things Required readings: - Shalvi, S., Gino, F., Barkan, R., & Ayal, S. (2015). Self-serving justifications: Doing wrong and feeling moral. <i>Current Directions in Psychological Science</i>, 24(2), 125-130. - Ariely (2009). <i>Our buggy moral code</i>. [VIDEO]
	Thurs 2/6	Mini lecture & discussion topic: Self-control as the moral muscle: can self-control stop us from acting immorally? Are all self-control failures immoral? Required readings: Baumeister, R. F., & Juola Exline, J. (1999). Virtue, personality, and social relations: Self-control as the moral muscle. <i>Journal of personality</i>, 67(6), 1165-1194.
	Sun 2/9	<i>Midterm 1 Due</i>
Week 6 – Moral reasoning	Tues 2/11	Lecture topic: Trolley problems and other moral dilemmas Required readings: Greene, J. D., Cushman, F. A., Stewart, L. E., Lowenberg, K., Nystrom, L. E., & Cohen, J. D. (2009). Pushing moral buttons: The interaction between personal force and intention in moral judgment. <i>Cognition</i>, 111(3), 364-371.
	Thurs 2/13	Mini lecture & discussion topic: Should we strive to be more effective altruists? Required readings: Caviola, L., Schubert, S., & Greene, J. D. (2021). The psychology of (in)effective altruism. <i>Trends in Cognitive Sciences</i>, 25(7), 596-607.
	Sun 2/16	<i>Quiz 3 Due</i>
Week 7 – Moral judgment & responsibility	Tues 2/18	Lecture topic: Social intuitionism and harmless wrongs (or: is it wrong to eat your dog?) Required readings: Haidt, J. (2001). The emotional dog and its rational tail: a social intuitionist approach to moral judgment. <i>Psychological review</i>, 108(4), 814.
	Thurs 2/20	Mini lecture & discussion topic: When do we excuse someone from moral responsibility? Required readings: Nobes, G., Panagiotaki, G., & Martin, J. W. (2023). Moral luck and the roles of outcome and negligence in moral judgments. <i>Journal of Experimental Social Psychology</i>, 106, 104456.
	Sun 2/23	<i>Research Paper First Draft Due (Optional)</i>

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Commented [SD3]: Switch out for book excerpt?

Week 8 – Social judgment	Tues 2/25	Lecture topic: Moral impression formation: Sorting the good apples from the bad Required readings: Helzer, E. G., & Critcher, C. R. (2018). What do we evaluate when we evaluate moral character. In K. Gray & J. Graham (Eds.) <i>Atlas of moral psychology</i>, 99-107.
	Thurs 2/27	Mini lecture & discussion topic: Does telling people about your good deeds make you appear <i>less</i> moral? Required readings: - Berman, J. Z., & Silver, I. (2022). Prosocial behavior and reputation: When does doing good lead to looking good? <i>Current opinion in psychology</i>, 43, 10s2-107. - Newman, G. E., & Cain, D. M. (2014). Tainted altruism: When doing some good is evaluated as worse than doing no good at all. <i>Psychological science</i>, 25(3), 648-655.
	Sun 3/2	<i>Quiz 4 Due</i>
Week 9 – Religion	Tues 3/4	Lecture topic: Religious and secular methods of deterrence: Does religion make people more moral? Required readings: - Gervais, W. M. (2014). Everything is permitted? People intuitively judge immorality as representative of atheists. <i>PloS one</i>, 9(4), e92302. - Tsang, J. A., Al-Kire, R. L., & Ratchford, J. L. (2021). Prosociality and religion. <i>Current Opinion in Psychology</i>, 40, 67-72.
	Thurs 3/6	Mini-lecture & discussion topic: Do purity concerns belong in the moral domain? Required readings: Gray, K., DiMaggio, N., Schein, C., & Kachanoff, F. (2023). The problem of purity in moral psychology. <i>Personality and Social Psychology Review</i>, 27(3), 272-308.
	Sun 3/9	<i>Midterm 2 Due</i>
Week 10 – Politics	Tues 3/11	Lecture topic: Two Americas? Liberal versus conservative morality Required readings: - Haidt (2012). <i>The moral roots of liberals and conservatives</i> [VIDEO]. - Womick et al. (2024). Moral Disagreement across Politics is Explained by Different Assumptions about who is Most Vulnerable to Harm.
	Thurs 3/13	Mini-lecture & discussion topic: Can and should we try to change people's moral beliefs? Required readings: Cazzell, A. R. (Host). (2020, March 31). The Stubbornness of Convictions with Linda Skitka [Audio Podcast].
Finals week		<i>Final Research Paper Due Monday, March 17 @ 11:59pm</i>